propose adequate reconciliation mechanisms by the end of 1995 undermined India's internationalist strategy in Afghanistan. However, until this point India firmly hoped that the UN-led approach would work.

For India, the UN could have been successful in brokering peace in Afghanistan but only if Mestiri recognised Pakistan's open, and controversial, support to the Taliban. Accepting this fact would have strengthened Indian claims that Pakistan was using military coercion both in Afghanistan and Kashmir. This, however, did not happen. Remaining defensive at the UN over Pakistan's allegations of Indian military's human rights violations in Kashmir, New Delhi struggled to keep the Kashmir issue a bilateral matter with Pakistan. Wanting to bring Kashmir into the international spotlight on one hand, Pakistan wanted India to keep out of Afghanistan on the other. According to the MEA, 'India effectively countered efforts by Pakistan to get the UN and its agencies to pass resolutions against India on issues of human rights and Kashmir'.[94] Engagement with different Afghan factions and accepting the UN-led process became imperative in this context. Kabul's fall in September 1996 left India clueless as its capacity constraints had already limited its policy options in Afghanistan. In the meantime, all other regional players found their favourites. Iran threw its weight behind the Shiite and Hazara-dominated *Hizb-e-Wahdat* and Herat's Ismael Khan, while Uzbekistan with Moscow's support backed Dostum in the north and Massoud in Kabul. According to Raghunath and Saran, India did not view the situation as much in ethnic terms, but increasingly saw it in its interest to support anti-Taliban outfits.[95]

Persian connection

Iran was pivotal in tilting the balance in the favour of partisans after Kabul's fall. The rise of the Taliban, a Sunni militant group supported by Saudi Arabia and the US, went against Shia-dominated Iran's regional interests. The UN's failure to broker peace led Iran to seize the opportunity to conduct an international conference on Afghanistan on 29–30 October 1996. Coming after months of shuttle diplomacy by Iranian diplomats, the conference witnessed a confluence of interests between every regional player barring Pakistan. Islamabad's aversion to